PRE-SEED · $1M · 2026

Crypto-backed lending infrastructure for *credit unions.*

Aetherum enables credit unions to offer crypto-collateralized loans to their members — keeping the regulatory bar that keeps competitors out.

140M	$2.2T	$0
CU MEMBERS IN THE US	CU ASSETS UNDER MANAGEMENT	B2B CRYPTO LENDING INFRASTRUCTURE

01 · PROBLEM

Credit unions are *locked out* of crypto lending.

140 million Americans trust their credit union over any bank. But when those members want to unlock liquidity from their Bitcoin or Ethereum holdings, they're forced to go to D2C lenders like Nexo or Ledn — or sell, triggering a taxable event.

Credit unions want to serve these members. The regulatory complexity is the barrier — not the appetite.

01 No compliant crypto lending infrastructure exists for NCUA-regulated institutions

02 D2C competitors (Nexo, Ledn, SALT) aren't B2B — they compete with CUs, not serve them

03 Younger members with crypto assets are migrating to fintech — CUs are losing them

04 No risk assessment model purpose-built for crypto collateral under NCUA guidelines exists

05 BitGo, Plaid, and KYC/AML integration requires months of compliance work per institution

02 · SOLUTION

The *full stack* a credit union needs to go live.

01 · Lending Engine

Crypto-Collateralized Loans

Members keep their BTC/ETH exposure, avoid the taxable sale, and receive USD liquidity at 8–12% APR. Real-time LTV monitoring with automated margin calls.

02 · Risk

DACS™ Risk Assessment

Dynamic Asset Credit Scoring — a patent-pending six-pillar risk model purpose-built for crypto collateral. Described as a "risk assessment model" throughout, per Plaid compliance guidance.

03 · Custody

BitGo Institutional Custody

Each credit union holds its own direct BitGo account. Member wallets live within the CU's structure. Aetherum is the software layer only — we never touch member assets.

04 · Compliance

Plaid + Sardine Integration

Plaid Check (CRA bundle) approved and live across 6 core products. Sardine KYC/AML/fraud under MSA negotiation. Compliance-first architecture from day one.

05 · Distribution

CU Distribution Network

Board advisor with deep institutional roots across the CU ecosystem — NACUSO Regulatory Advocacy Committee, CUNA Payments Subcommittee, and Chair of Ongoing Operations LLC.

06 · Platform

Full-Stack Infrastructure

Portfolio tracker, collateral calculator, staking module, and DACS gauge — all live at test-app.aetherum.ai. TypeScript/NestJS backend, React frontend, deployed on Railway.

07 · Yield

Staking Module

Members can stake supported digital assets directly through the platform — earning yield while maintaining collateral eligibility for crypto-backed loans. Adds a yield layer to the Aetherum product suite, deepening member engagement and creating an additional revenue stream for credit union partners. Coming Soon.

08 · Tax Intelligence

Tax-Position Score & Collateral Optimizer (TPSOE™)

The TPSOE engine scores the tax efficiency of every collateral position in a member's portfolio — ranking assets by embedded tax liability so the optimal pledge set is always selected. Members borrow smarter, not just more: no taxable event, no unnecessary capital gains exposure. The Collateral Optimizer computes UGLV and TAEV per asset, selects the lowest tax-cost collateral set that satisfies LTV requirements, and surfaces estimated tax savings to the member. Patent-pending sixth DACS pillar. No B2B competitor offers this to institutions.

03 · MARKET

A massive, *unserved* market.

The credit union ecosystem is one of the largest financial networks in the US — and the last major institutional channel without crypto lending infrastructure.

140M	5,000+	$1.2M
CREDIT UNION MEMBERS IN THE UNITED STATES	CREDIT UNIONS REACHABLE THROUGH VELERA ALONE	TARGET ARR AT 10 CUS × 100 LOANS/MONTH

04 · TRACTION

Built to the *compliance bar* that keeps others out.

PLAID	Plaid Check (CRA bundle) approved and live	— 6 core products active. Production approval used as investor data room leverage.
SARDINE	KYC/AML/fraud integration.	Named to Mastercard's Crypto Partner Program (March 2026) — validating our compliance infrastructure at the institutional level.
BITGO	Enterprise custody account live.	Each CU holds its own account — Aetherum never touches assets. Named to Mastercard's Crypto Partner Program (March 2026).
MASTERCARD	Independent institutional validation.	Mastercard's Crypto Partner Program (March 2026) includes both our custody provider (BitGo) and compliance provider (Sardine) — confirming our infrastructure stack operates at the institutional standard.
DACS™	Patent pending.	Six-pillar risk model, live gauge wired to API. Includes TPSOE as sixth pillar.

TPSOE™	Patent pending — second provisional filing.	Tax-Position Score & Collateral Optimizer ranks pledge assets by embedded tax liability. No B2B competitor offers this to institutions.
DISTRIBUTION	Steve Salzer, SVP & General Counsel at Velera — Board Advisor to Aetherum.	Chairs the Board of Ongoing Operations LLC and sits on the NACUSO Regulatory Advocacy Committee and CUNA Payments Subcommittee.
PLATFORM	~80% complete	— live at test-app.aetherum.ai across 6 Railway services. Demo accounts available on request.
BD PIPELINE	Active outreach	to Coastal Federal CU and GLCU Holdings. NACUSO and Curql fund relationships in progress.

05 · REVENUE MODEL

Four streams. *Platform-fee led.*

Revenue is tied directly to loan volume — meaning we grow as our credit union partners grow. The SaaS license layer adds predictable recurring revenue at scale.

ARR TARGET

$1K/loan × 100 loans/mo × 10 CUs = $1.2M ARR

Tax Intelligence add-on layer creates additional recurring revenue per CU partner.

70%

Platform Fees

$500–$1,500 per loan originated. Primary revenue driver tied to volume.

20%

Transaction Fees

0.5–1% on crypto collateral transactions processed through the platform.

10%

SaaS License

$50K–$150K/year for large credit unions. Predictable ARR layer at scale.

New

Tax Intelligence Module

$10K–25K/year per credit union as a premium add-on. Tells members not just what they can borrow — but which assets to pledge and how much they save in taxes by borrowing instead of selling. No B2B competitor offers this to institutions.

06 · TEAM & ADVISORS

Built by operators.
Advised by the ecosystem.

John Bailey

FOUNDER & CEO

20+ years in technical recruiting with placements at Google, Spotify, and Goldman Sachs. Previously co-founded Thorium Data (Data Catalog). Building Aetherum full-time since early 2025, managing all product, BD, fundraising, and technical implementation.

Steve Salzer

BOARD ADVISOR · SVP, VELERA

SVP, Enterprise Risk Office & General Counsel at Velera since 2017. Chairs the Board of Managers at Ongoing Operations LLC. Sits on the NACUSO Regulatory Advocacy Committee and CUNA Payments Subcommittee. JD, University of Chicago Law School.

Rahul Goel

ADVISOR · JP MORGAN / UBER

Cybersecurity and financial infrastructure expertise from senior roles at JP Morgan and Uber, including involvement with Meta's Novi digital wallet. Advises on platform security architecture and institutional trust.

Saiprasad Raut

ADVISOR · WORLDPAY / VANAR

Head of Payments Infrastructure at Vanar, formerly Worldpay. Deep payments and blockchain infrastructure expertise guiding Aetherum's settlement and custody architecture.

07 · THE ASK

Closing a *$1M pre-seed* round.

We're in the final stretch of closing our pre-seed round. Proceeds go toward closing the first two credit union pilots, completing platform development, and bringing on a CTO.

ROUND SIZE	$1,000,000
INSTRUMENT	Post-Money SAFE
VALUATION CAP	$8M Post-Money
DISCOUNT	20%
TIMELINE	Closing Mid-April 2026

REQUEST A DEMO

Let's talk.

20 minutes. We'll walk through the platform live and answer any diligence questions.

BOOK A CALL

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